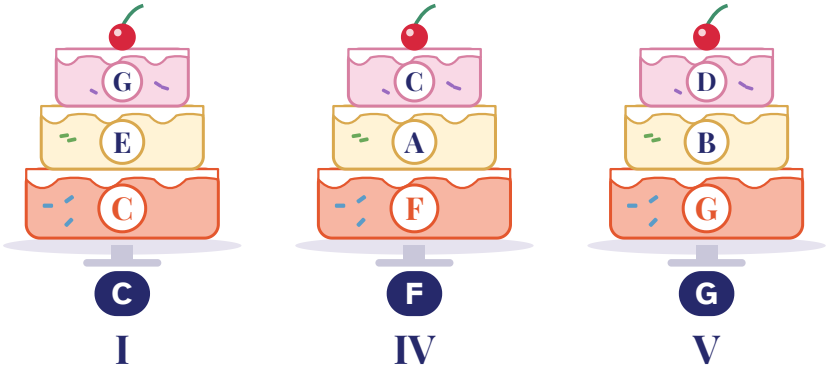
LESSON 1

Find the chord

Most simple tunes need only **three chords**: I, IV and V. Your job is to choose one for each bar. The tune tells you which: look at its main notes and pick the cake that holds them.
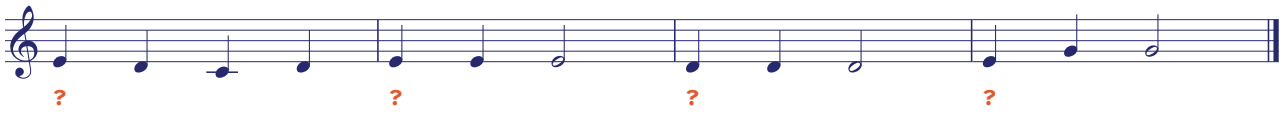


The three cakes of C major: between them they hold every note of the scale

THE RULE

Main notes are the ones on beat 1 and beat 3, and the long ones. Find the cake that holds them. If two cakes fit, let your ear choose.

EXAMPLE

Choose a chord for each bar



1. **Bar 1:** the main notes are E and C. Which cake holds both?
2. **Bar 3:** D D D. Which cake has a D in it?
3. **Write a chord name** where each ? is.

Bars 1, 2 and 4 take **C** (C E G holds E, C and G). Bar 3 takes **G** (G B D holds D).

YOU KNOW THIS

Mary Had a Little Lamb, with its chords



C | C | G | C | C | C | G | C

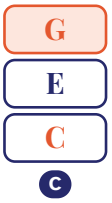
Only **two chords**, C and G, carry the whole tune. The chord names sit under the first note of each bar.

Try it. Play the tune with your right hand and say the chord name at the start of each bar.

LESSON 1 · CONTINUED

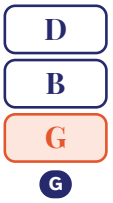
EXAMPLE

When two cakes fit



1 **The bar is G G G.** Which cakes have a G in them?

2 **Look at the bar before** and the bar after: which chord are they?



3 **Play both** and choose: staying put, or moving?

Both C and G hold G. After a C bar, staying on **C** sounds calm; moving to **G** sounds like the tune is going somewhere. Both are right: you choose the mood.

GAME

Which cake holds the bar?

1	2	3	4
E D C D	D D D	G G G	F A F A

All in C major. Pick I (C), IV (F) or V (G) for each bar.

Answer: 1 C · 2 G · 3 C or G (G is in both: let your ear choose) · 4 F.

GAME

Your turn: Twinkle

1	2
C C G G	A A G
3	**4**
F F E E	D D C

Twinkle in C major. Choose I, IV or V for each half bar.

Answer: 1 C · 2 F, then C · 3 F, then C · 4 G, then C.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Find D in the cakes.

D is only in the G cake. B too. So whenever a bar leans on D or B, G is your chord.

THINK OF IT Like choosing shoes for an outfit: you look at the big pieces, not every button.

TRAP

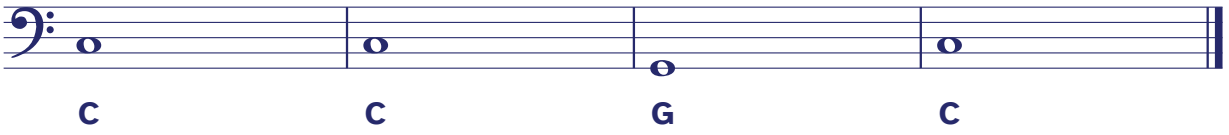
- × Choosing a chord for every single note: one chord per bar (sometimes two) is plenty.
- × Using the passing notes: the short notes between the main ones can belong to any chord.

LESSON 2

Your left hand joins in

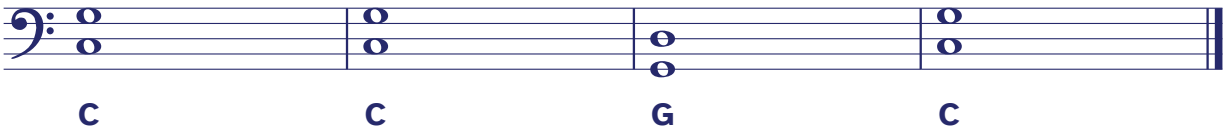
Now the left hand plays the chord you chose. Start tiny: one note. When it feels easy, add a note. Then the whole cake. Same chord, three sizes.

Step 1



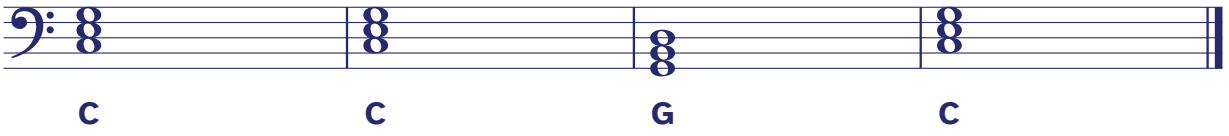
Just the **bottom layer**: the chord's own name note, held for the whole bar.

Step 2



Add the **top layer**: bottom and top together (C and G). Strong and open.

Step 3



The **whole cake**: all three notes at once. Full and warm.

THE RULE
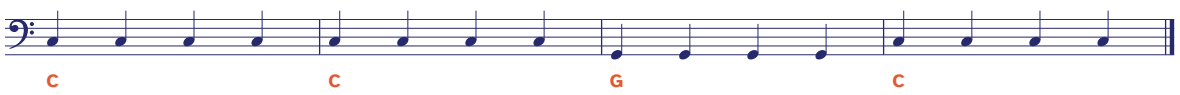
Pick the step that feels easy, play the tune with it, then move up one step. Nobody hears which step you use; everybody hears whether it is steady.

STEP	SOUNDS	GOOD FOR
1 · bottom layer	light, simple	lullabies, first tries
2 · bottom + top	strong, open	marches, folk songs
3 · whole cake	full, warm	hymns, ballads, the last chord

LESSON 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Make it pulse



?

1. **Choose the chords** for Mary (Lesson 1): C C G C.
2. **Play the bottom layer** on every beat instead of holding it. How many notes in each bar?
3. **Keep the right hand** playing the tune on top.

Four even notes per bar: **C C C C**, then G G G G in bar 3. The left hand is now the drummer, and the tune sounds alive.

EXAMPLE 2

Step 2 on G



1. **Build the G cake:** skip one, take the next.
2. **Step 2** keeps only two layers. Which two?
3. **Play them** low in the left hand.

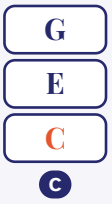
The bottom and top layers: **G and D**. The middle B can wait for step 3.

HOW TO

Practise it in three rounds

1. **Round 1:** left hand alone, step 1, counting 1 2 3 4.
2. **Round 2:** right hand tune with left hand step 1.
3. **Round 3:** the same with step 2, then step 3.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hold C, sing Mary.

Left hand holds C E G while you sing the first two bars. Then switch to G B D for bar 3. You are accompanying!

THINK OF IT A band starts small: first the drummer, then the bass, then the whole band. Your left hand is all three, one step at a time.

TRAP

- × Rushing at the chord change: the left hand moves on beat 1, not before.
- × Playing the left hand as loud as the tune: the tune is the singer, the left hand the band.